myriad problems and setbacks which frequently drained the independent operator's financial resources down to a point well below the danger mark.

In addition, all of us who operated independently often found ourselves facing heavy competition and opposition from major oil firms. Some of these huge companies did not always abide by Marquis of Queensberry rules when they engaged in legal or financial infighting to smother an independent who appeared to be growing too big or too fast.

Wildcatters developed traits and techniques which enabled them to stay in business and to do more than merely hold their own against the petroleum industry's behemoths. We became flexible, adaptable and versatile—

adept at improvisation and innovation—if for no other reason than because we *had* to in order to survive. For example, the big companies employed vast numbers of specialists and consultants, administrative personnel and office workers, housing them in large and expensive offices.

We, the independents, found our experts among the hard-bitten, veteran oil-field workers who formed our prospecting and drilling crews, or we relied on our own judgment and experience to solve our problems as they arose. We did our own administrative and paper work—

keeping both to a minimum. As for our offices, these—more often than not—traveled with us in the mud-splotched automobiles we drove from one drilling site to another.

As I have said, I was lucky—very lucky. I made many profitable deals and brought in several producing wells in the months after I first struck oil on the Nancy Taylor Allotment site. The Getty Oil Company prospered. I was named one of the company's directors and elected its secretary, but this did not mean I exchanged my work clothes for a business suit. Notwithstanding my heady new titles, my work was still in the oil fields—and on the drilling rigs. My role in the company's affairs remained the